

frugality as a fun lifestyle—if anything, it’s the opposite. They see it as a lifestyle of deprivation, exploiting resources, and mooching off people. And for years we thought we were addressing this misconception on our podcast by teaching people how to save money on this, spend less on that, and ways to avoid buying home decor. (Here’s the best hack: Take it away from its beautifully curated display and look at it next to a trash can to determine if it still looks good in an unaesthetic environment.) But we were looking at the “how,” not the “why,” and definitely not the “who.”

Amber’s email served as a reminder that a number in a bank account is a good short-term motivator for cleaning up your spending habits, but it doesn’t last. We are people. Not bank accounts. Any real chance we have at achieving our financial goals is going to take time. They say “It’s a marathon, not a sprint,” but it’s way more than a marathon. A marathon is still something that can be run in a day. Financial goals can take decades to achieve. And who wants to live decades without having any fun? The pandemic showed us that you can work hard your whole life to save or build a business and still lose everything due to circumstances outside of your control. So, what’s the point in trying so hard? These are the questions our listener was asking. We knew them well because we’ve asked them too. And when we look to authorities in the world of finance for answers, they all seem to fall short.

Typical personal finance advice has long been a tool that out-of-touch financial experts use to give the rest of us just enough illusion of control that we continue to buy their books and courses and pay them commissions to manage our money for us. But most of the traditional finance advice given is for people who already have money. It’s full of math, numbers, and spreadsheets. And any money-saving advice is typically a list of 100+ things to do to save a dollar here and a dollar there. We’re told a budget is the solution to all our money problems, and if you can’t stick to one, it’s not the budget’s fault, it’s your lack of self-control. If you can’t stop eating at restaurants or getting lattes, it’s a self-discipline problem, not a time or stress issue. There’s always a seven-step program and someone saying “If I can do it, you can too.”

But in reality, the math ain’t mathin’. And maybe it’s because none of these experts had the math teachers we did. Ours always required us to “show your work.” In every other class, simply having the answer was enough. Not in math class. Having the answer only provided partial credit,